

Jay Sylvester

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Product, design, and engineering leader with 20+ years spanning UX, product, and full-stack development, including 8+ years managing teams. I'm the Head of Product at an AI-native startup, where I own strategy and design and ship the production frontend myself. As the first design hire at multiple B2B SaaS startups, I've taken complex technical products from 0 to 1 by anchoring decisions in customer research and building the design and research practice where none existed.

CORE COMPETENCIES

Product management: strategy, roadmap ownership, discovery, requirements definition, and 0-to-1 delivery

Team leadership: hiring, mentoring, and scaling cross-functional design and frontend teams

User research: contextual inquiry, moderated usability studies, interview programs, heuristic evaluation

Product design: interaction design, information architecture, design systems, data visualization, UI copy

Full-stack development: Next.js, React, JavaScript, Node.js, HTML/CSS, PostgreSQL/SQL, Git, Linux

AI-native product development: agent design, system and inline prompt engineering, human-in-the-loop workflows

EXPERIENCE

Head of Product — Flisk

2023 – Present

- Co-founded an AI-native startup building an agent for tag management and data tracking. It handles implementation, monitoring, maintenance, and documentation so marketing and analytics teams can ship tracking without an engineer.
- Own product strategy and roadmap end to end. Established product-market fit through 200+ customer discovery interviews across publishers, multi-brand e-commerce, and analytics agencies.
- Architected the agent's behavior, writing the primary system prompt and all inline prompt engineering that governs UI actions, plan generation, and staged approvals.
- Designed the full product experience in Figma and validated it across 30+ moderated usability studies, turning a highly technical workflow into plain-language interaction that non-technical users can trust.
- Defined the human-in-the-loop model, in which the agent drafts a plan, writes the code, and stages changes for the customer to review and approve, so automation never outruns the judgment the work requires.
- Build and ship the production frontend in Next.js and React, using LLMs/agents to compress the design-to-implementation cycle and prototype directly in code.

Lead Product Designer — Rockerbox

2022 – 2023

- Established the product design and user research functions as the company's first design hire, embedding research into roadmap and planning conversations.
- Reframed product direction after research showed that customers struggled to interpret the data rather than to navigate the interface, shifting the platform from raw attribution tables toward guided insights and specific recommendations.
- Led design for Channel Overlap, Goals & Recommendations (automated ad-spend recommendations with deliberate guardrails on how far the system would push a change), and Marketing Mix Modeling for the largest accounts.
- Moderated 100+ customer interviews and usability tests, using remote contextual inquiry to observe how marketers actually worked rather than how they described their work.
- Presented design work at quarterly company meetings and socialized UX practice across product, engineering, and go-to-market.

Principal UX Designer — Equinix

2021 – 2022

- Led a cross-functional team through the redesign of Equinix Metal's colocation admin interface.
- Designed new UI patterns that streamlined bare-metal resource deployment for enterprise infrastructure customers.

UX Manager — Linode

2019 – 2020

- Managed the UX and frontend development teams through a ground-up redesign of the Linode Cloud Manager.

- Set explicit design goals for information density, IA consistency, accessibility, and a dashboard that adapts to fleet size, after research showed a large share of customers ran only a single instance.
- Fixed accessibility failures in status indicators for colorblind users by pairing color with text labels and a sortable status column.
- Built the company's first qualitative user research program, writing test scripts, building functional prototypes, moderating usability studies, and mentoring the team on research methodology.
- Validated the redesign through an open beta before general release, iterating on feedback ahead of full rollout.

UX Lead — Vidyo

2015 – 2018

- Led the UX team responsible for research and design across an entire suite of video conferencing products, aligning the team's work with user needs and business goals.
- Managed senior designers who ran their own teams and projects, and mentored junior designers in user research, information architecture, and interaction design.

UX Lead — Hibu

2012 – 2013

- Led a cross-disciplinary team of UX designers and frontend developers through a responsive redesign of the company's core e-commerce platform.
- Rearchitected and rebuilt the frontend codebase for improved performance, consistency, and maintainability across multiple dev teams and work streams.

Manager of Frontend Development — Abercrombie & Fitch

2010 – 2012

- Managed a large team of UI engineers through a complete redesign of Abercrombie's e-commerce sites and an overhaul of the frontend codebase.
- Built partnerships across UX, marketing, and IT that broke down long-standing silos and established the business case for user-centered design inside a traditional retail organization.

Independent Consultant, Product Design & Frontend Development

2013 – 2021

Delivered product design, user research, and frontend development engagements for a range of clients, working solo and embedded on client teams. Engagements spanned discovery and research, interaction design and prototyping, design system work, and production frontend implementation.

Please see my LinkedIn profile for additional work history and professional recommendations.

OPEN SOURCE

citizen — a Node.js MVC web application framework

2013 – Present

github.com/jaysylvester/citizen

- Sole author and maintainer of a server-side application framework spanning routing, view rendering, session management, in-memory caching, hot module replacement, compression, form handling, and CORS. Roughly 300 commits across a decade of active development, published on npm.
- Designed the framework around convention over configuration to reduce dependency sprawl, applying the same interaction-design instincts to an API built for developer ergonomics.
- Runs in production on my own sites, including a community platform serving several hundred thousand monthly page views from a single instance on a \$30/month cloud plan, with the process staying up for months at a time between restarts.

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Arts, English — Pennsylvania State University

TOOLS & TECHNOLOGIES

Figma, Sketch, Cursor, Jira, Confluence, Notion, Slack, Git, Linux, SSH, Terminal, Next.js, React, JavaScript, Node.js, HTML, CSS, PostgreSQL, SQL, Agile, Design Systems, Accessibility, B2B and B2C SaaS, Cloud Computing, Developer Tools